

CHAPTER SIX

I Can Change and Grow

By the end of October, Maya was a little louder.

Not a lot louder. Not loud, exactly. But louder than she had been on the first day of school, when she could not answer Sammy's question about what made her special, and Ms. Calloway had said Sammy already knows you are here.

Maya had a few favorite things now. She had a favorite spot on the carpet (the corner near the bookshelf). She had a favorite color of crayon (the dark blue, the kind that looks almost like the night). She had a favorite friend at lunch (Sofia, because Sofia did not talk too much during eating, which Maya appreciated).

She also had a small idea, in the back of her head, that had not been there in September.

The idea was: I can be different from how I started.

Maya had not put the idea into words yet. She did not have all the words. But the idea was there, growing slowly, the way the bean plants in the science corner of Room 12 were growing slowly, even though it looked, day to day, like nothing was happening to them.

On the last Friday of October, Ms. Calloway put a chart on the easel that the kids had not seen before.

At the top of the chart, it said: I AM A WORK IN PROGRESS.

"Friends," said Ms. Calloway, "I want to tell you about something today. It is one of the most important things I will

tell you this year. So listen."

She paused. The class leaned in.

"You are not finished," said Ms. Calloway. "None of you. You are not done becoming who you are. You are in the middle of becoming who you are. Every day, you become a little bit more of who you are going to be. You are a work in progress."

She pointed at the chart.

"This means that if you were quiet in September — you might not be quiet in March. This means that if you were scared of math in September — you might love math by May. This means that if you knocked over a block tower in September — by next year, you might be the kid who builds block towers."

Marcus grinned.

"This means," said Ms. Calloway, "that nobody — nobody in this room, nobody in this school, nobody in this town, nobody in this country, nobody in this whole world — gets to tell you who you ARE going to be. They can tell you who you ARE RIGHT NOW. Right now is a thing about you. But who you are RIGHT NOW is not who you are FOREVER. Because — say it with me, friends — you are a work in progress."

The class said, in ten small voices, I am a work in progress. "Again," said Ms. Calloway.

I am a work in progress.

"One more time."

I AM A WORK IN PROGRESS.

Then Ms. Calloway took out a piece of paper and gave one to each child, and on the paper there were two columns. The left column said Me in September. The right column said Me Now.

"Draw a picture of yourself in September," she said. "And then draw a picture of yourself today. Do not worry about

making them perfect. Just show me how it feels."

Maya looked at her piece of paper.

She drew a picture in the September column of a small girl with a sad mouth, sitting on a carpet, with her eyes looking down.

Then she looked at the Right Now column for a long time.

She drew a picture of a small girl, still small, still sitting on a carpet — but this time with her eyes looking up. Looking at something. Looking at — Maya thought about it, and then she added one more thing — looking at a small green frog puppet sitting on a shelf.

She turned the paper in to Ms. Calloway during quiet work time. Ms. Calloway looked at the paper for a long moment.

She did not say anything. She just put her hand, very gently, on the top of Maya's head.

Maya did not know it, but Ms. Calloway kept that picture in her file all year, and at the end of the year, she gave it back to Maya in an envelope, with one line written on the back.

The line said: Maya. You looked up. — Ms. C.

That picture is going to come back later, in a chapter you have not read yet.

For now, just remember: Maya looked up.

That is a thing she did. That is a thing she became. She was not always going to be a girl who looked up. In September, she had not been one. But by the end of October, she was on her way.

That is what it means to be a work in progress.